Shvi'i Shel Pesach

Going Into the Water

Kriyas Yam Suf • Emunah • Isaruta d'Letata • Going Deeper into Torah

I want to open with something a little personal, something I am admittedly a bit spoiled to be able to bring. I am a scuba diver. I love going under the water. And when you are down there, what you see is what Hashem is holding back. The entire world beneath the surface — the life, the color, the depth — is invisible to anyone who stays on shore.

This perspective on Shvi'i shel Pesach, on Kriyas Yam Suf, is one I find myself coming back to every year. Because the question of the sea is not primarily a question about a miracle. It is a question about whether you are willing to go in.

I. Seven, Nature, and What Lies Beneath

Sheva is *teva* — the word for nature has the numerical value of seven. The seventh is *Shabbos*, the seventh *Yom Tov* of Pesach, the seven *sefirot* below, the seven weeks of *Sefiras HaOmer*. Seven is the full cycle of the natural world. And *shmoneh*, eight, is above nature — which is also why in Parshas Shemini the *avodah* in the Mishkan begins specifically on the eighth day.

The *derech* of nature when it comes to water is simple: if you go in and try to breathe, it is not going to work out well. There is a *pachad* there, a deep, almost primal fear that comes with being underwater, because it is not the norm. The body knows it does not belong there.

A friend of mine from one of my *chaburos* shared something with me once. As a child, his father took him scuba diving. He had a full tank on his back. By every measure, he had what he needed. But he panicked. Where a normal diver on a standard tank lasts around an hour, he was back on the surface in ten or fifteen minutes. The fear was too strong. The unknown was too much. The fact that he had everything he needed was not enough to overcome what he felt the moment he went under.

That is the *pachad* of the sea. And that is exactly where *Klal Yisrael* stood on Shvi'i shel Pesach.

II. Water and Historical Fear

But there is a layer even deeper than the natural fear of water, and that is the historical one. *Klal Yisrael* did not come to the sea without a memory. They carried the *mabul*, the flood that had unmade the world. They had watched the Nile turn to blood. They had seen

frogs come up out of the water. They knew that water could shift, overnight, from life to death.

Standing at the *Yam* was not just physically frightening. It was emotionally and historically frightening. Everything in their experience told them that water was unstable, that it could turn on you, that it was not safe ground.

And yet Hashem says: go in.

The Sages teach us something remarkable about the nature of what they were being asked to enter:

אֵין מַיִם אֶלָּא תוֹרָה

"Water refers to nothing other than Torah."

— Bava Kama 17a

Up until this moment, even with the *Korban Pesach* behind them, *Klal Yisrael* had been looking at Torah from the outside. Individuals — the *Avos*, the yeshivos of Shem and Ever — had gone deep. But as a *Kahal*, as a nation, they had not yet entered. And entering is a frightening thing. Not because Torah is dangerous, but because the depths are unknown, and the unknown takes courage.

III. Isaruta d'Letata: The Movement From Below

In *Chassidus* we speak of two complementary movements: *Isaruta d'Letata* and *Isaruta d'Le'eila* — an awakening from below that draws down a response from above. Hashem gives the instruction, but we still have to wake ourselves up. We have to move first.

We saw this already before *Yetzias Mitzrayim*. When *Klal Yisrael* cried out, when they had those bitter tears — that was the *isaruta d'letata*. And Hashem heard. Hashem responded. The pattern was already established. The movement from below draws the response from above.

Now they are at the sea. The instruction is to go forward. And it took one person to actually do it.

Nachshon goes in. And he does something interesting as he goes — he speaks. *Mi Chamocha, Mi Kamocha*. The water starts rising. It reaches his waist, his chest, his neck, his lips. And he continues. He keeps moving. He keeps speaking. He is going into the Torah, physically and verbally at the same time — combining action and speech into a single, complete *avodah*.

I am known, among my dive partners, to sing underwater. They have watched me do it. There is something about being in the depths that opens up expression rather than closing it down. Nachshon understood this. He did not go silent when the water rose. He went deeper and kept speaking the words. That is what Hashem responds to. Not the absence of fear, but the movement forward despite it.

IV. The Splitting: Miracle Within Nature

And then the sea splits.

But notice what happens. The water does not disappear. The Torah was not broken. The *pasuk* says:

וַיֵּלְכוּ בְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל בַּיַּבָּשָׁה בְּתוֹךְ הַיָּם

"The children of Israel walked on dry land in the midst of the sea."

— Shemos 14:22

Dry land *inside* the sea. Both are true simultaneously. The water remains — rising as walls on either side. What is happening inside is above nature, and yet the natural world is still fully present around it. It is normal to walk on dry land. It is normal to walk together with your people. But to do that surrounded by walls of water, held back by Hashem on every side — that is something entirely beyond.

There are *mefarshim* who say that each *shevet* had its own separate path through the sea. Each tribe experienced the depth in its own way. This is the *Isaruta d'Le'eila* — Hashem responding to the movement from below, and showing them not just a way through, but the beauty that was always there beneath the surface.

They walked through. They had sustenance. They saw things. They came out the other side and said: what a gift. We experienced the Torah. We saw *nissim* before — the *makos*, the punishments, the lessons. But this was for us. This was personal. Hashem was showing us how much He wants to bring us inside.

V. The Fear That Returns — and the Test of the Treasures

And then something happens. Fear comes back.

They turn and they see the Mitzrim approaching. They see them moving toward the water. And there is a question that must have risen in their hearts: *I just did so much avodah. I trusted Hashem. I went into the unknown. I risked everything. It was beautiful. And now they get this too? The same people who tried to destroy us are going to enter the same water and experience the same thing?*

And Hashem says: no.

There is a sacred space inside the water, inside the depths. And when the Mitzrim go in, Hashem closes the waters. Those who try to enter something that is not for them, who try to take what they did not earn, who come in with force and entitlement rather than with *emunah* and *avodah* — it does not work. I am not saying this from any kind of superiority. We see this in life constantly. People try to take more than is meant for them. They try to manipulate systems, to get an upper hand. And often they get hurt. They get burned. The path that opens for the servant does not open in the same way for the one who forces his way in.

And there was another test as they came through: the treasures that rose up from the sea floor. The *mefarshim* describe riches, jewels, gifts rising with the waters. That too was a test. Not just to get through the sea, but to know what to do on the other side. To take what was given without losing focus. To receive the gift without making the gift the point.

Torah is a gift. It is beautiful. It is inviting. And we love Hashem for giving it to us. But the treasure is not the destination. The going deeper is the destination.

VI. Teaching a Child to Put Her Face in the Water

There is something very practical in all of this that I think about when I teach my daughter.

When you put on goggles and you put your face into the water for the first time, you might see something amazing. Or you might see something boring. Or you might see nothing at all. And that uncertainty — not knowing what you are going to find — is exactly what makes people afraid to go in.

But even when it looks boring, even when the water is murky and you cannot see much, there is depth. There is always more there. And the more you go in, the deeper you go, the more beauty you find. The more you experience. That is true of the ocean. It is true of Torah. It is true of *avodah*.

The *avodah* is to go in. To not be afraid. To keep going deeper. To trust that the beauty is there even before you can see it. Nachshon did not see the bottom of the sea before he stepped in. He trusted that what Hashem was holding was worth entering.

VII. From Sefirah to Sefirah

We should all have an amazing Shvi'i shel Pesach, growing from strength to strength, from *sefirah* to *sefirah*, as we build toward Matan Torah.

Each *sefirah* is a step deeper into the water. Each day of counting is an invitation to go a little further in, to let the Torah become a little more personal, to move from looking at the water to actually living inside it.

The sea is open. The depth is real. And Hashem is holding it back, waiting for us to come in.

חזק ואחזק

Reflection Questions

- *Where am I still acting like a freed slave — waiting for the path to be fully clear — instead of moving forward with emunah the way Nachshon did?*
- *What "water" in my life feels overwhelming or unknown, but may actually be an invitation deeper into Torah or avodah?*
- *Am I approaching the depths of my learning and my relationship with Hashem with curiosity and trust, or am I staying on the surface because I do not know what I will find?*